

Helping Hands Platform

User Manual

This manual covers every role on the platform: Donor, Delivery Volunteer, Service Provider, Children's Home, and Administrator. Find your role's section for step-by-step guidance, or read the Getting Started chapter first if this is your first time on the platform.

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1. What Is Helping Hands

Helping Hands is a web-based platform that connects verified, government-registered children's homes with donors, service providers, and delivery volunteers — coordinating physical donations and volunteer services transparently and safely, with no money changing hands on the platform itself.

The problem it solves: donation efforts for children's homes are often informal and hard to trust — donors can't easily verify a home is legitimate, homes struggle to communicate exactly what they need, and volunteer involvement with children carries real safety risks without proper screening. Helping Hands addresses all three by making verification, tracking, and accountability part of the platform itself rather than something arranged separately.

1.1 Who uses it

Role	What they do on the platform
Children's Home	Registers (with government documents), gets verified by an administrator, posts specific requests for goods or services, and confirms completion
Donor	Browses open requests and pledges to supply goods
Delivery Volunteer	Same as a Donor, but focused on transporting goods rather than supplying them — no direct, unsupervised contact with children involved
Service Provider	Offers a service (tuition, counselling, healthcare, sports coaching, maintenance); providers with in-person contact with children must pass a verified police clearance check before they can be approved
Administrator	Verifies Homes and Providers, moderates content, manages user accounts, and oversees the whole platform

1.2 What makes it different

- Every Children's Home is verified against real government registration documents before it can post anything.
- Every Service Provider with direct child contact must have a verified police clearance — no exceptions, enforced by the system itself, not just a policy on paper.
- Every request is tracked through a full lifecycle (from posted, to pledged, to delivered, to confirmed complete) with a visible history — nothing just "disappears" once pledged.
- Reputation is earned, not assumed: donors and providers build a score from completed requests, and a poor track record restricts future participation.
- No money is handled by the platform at all — it coordinates goods and services directly between real people.

2. How It Works — System Overview

At a high level, using the platform follows the same shape regardless of which role you're in:

1. A Children's Home registers and uploads its government registration documents.
2. An Administrator reviews those documents and approves (or rejects, with a reason) the Home.
3. Once approved, the Home posts a request — a specific need for goods (e.g. "20 pairs of school shoes") or a service (e.g. "weekly maths tutoring").
4. Donors, Delivery Volunteers, or Service Providers (depending on the request type) browse open requests and pledge to fulfil one — for goods, choosing upfront whether they'll deliver it themselves or need a volunteer.
5. The Home reviews the pledge and accepts it (or, rarely, cancels the request). Once accepted, the two of them can message each other directly on the request.
6. The person who pledged marks progress as they go — in progress, then delivered. If a requested volunteer pickup stalls for about a week, the Home can arrange its own alternative instead.
7. The Home confirms the request is genuinely complete, and can leave a rating for the donor or provider.

Every one of those steps is visible as a timestamped history on the request itself — anyone involved can see exactly what happened and when, not just the current status.

2.1 The verification layer

Two separate verification checks happen behind the scenes, both enforced by the system rather than left to trust:

- Children's Homes must be approved by an Administrator based on real registration documents before they can post a single request.
- Service Providers offering anything with direct, in-person child contact must have a verified police clearance on file — approval is blocked until that specific check passes, even if the rest of their profile looks fine.

2.2 Trust and safety after approval

Verification at sign-up isn't the only safeguard. The platform also tracks reputation scores from completed requests (a poor track record restricts future pledging), lets Administrators flag or remove inappropriate content at any time, and logs every significant action — verification decisions, suspensions, content moderation — in a permanent audit trail.

2.3 Email verification

New accounts must verify their email address before they can register a Home/Provider profile, post a request, pledge to one, or submit a rating. This is a hard requirement, not just a reminder — the relevant buttons are disabled with an explanation until the account is verified.

3. Getting Started

3.1 Creating an account

From the homepage, click "Login / Signup" and then "Register here". Fill in your name, a username, email address, password (at least 8 characters), and phone number, then choose the role that matches what you want to do:

Role	Choose this if you want to...
Donor	Give physical goods (food, clothing, books, medical supplies, educational materials)
Delivery Volunteer	Help transport donated goods to a home, without offering goods yourself
Service Provider	Offer a service — tuition, counselling, healthcare, sports coaching, or maintenance
Children's Home	Register your government-registered home to post requests

Note: Administrator accounts are never self-registered — they are created directly by an existing administrator for security reasons.

3.2 Verifying your email

After registering, you can use the platform immediately — you are not locked out while unverified. However, a banner will appear reminding you to verify your email. Check your inbox for a message with a verification link; if you don't see it within a few minutes, use the "Resend email" button on the banner.

3.3 Logging in

1. Go to the Login page and enter your username or email and password.
2. If you are an Administrator, you will be asked for a second step: a 6-digit code emailed to you, valid for 5 minutes. Enter it and click "Verify & Sign In".
3. If the code doesn't arrive, check your spam folder or click "Resend code" on the same screen.

3.4 Forgotten password

Click "Forgot your password?" on the login page and enter your email. If it matches an account, a reset link is sent — click it and choose a new password. For your security, the platform never confirms or denies whether a given email is registered.

4. Donor Guide

As a Donor, you browse requests for physical goods posted by verified Children's Homes and pledge to fulfil the ones you can help with.

4.1 Finding a request to fulfil

1. From your Dashboard, click "Browse Donation Requests", or use the "Donation Requests" link in the sidebar.
2. Use the Category and Urgency filters to narrow the list — for example, filter to "FOOD" and "CRITICAL" to find the most urgent food needs.
3. Click any request to see its full details, including the requesting home and quantity needed.

4.2 Pledging to a request

1. On a request's detail page, click "Pledge to Fulfil".
2. Choose how the goods will reach the home: "I'll deliver it myself" or "I need a delivery volunteer." This is decided upfront, not later.
3. The Children's Home will review your pledge and either accept it or, in rare cases, cancel the request.
4. Once accepted, mark the request "In Progress" when you begin preparing the donation, then "Delivered" once the goods have reached the home.
5. The home will confirm completion — at that point, they may leave you a rating.

Note: If you chose "I need a delivery volunteer" and there's no progress within about a week, the home will be notified and may arrange their own alternative (such as a paid courier). Your pledge stays credited to you either way — this only changes who handles the physical transport, not who gets credit for donating.

Note: If your account has received several low ratings, you may be temporarily restricted from pledging to new requests until your reputation improves. This protects Children's Homes from unreliable donors.

4.3 Your dashboard

Your Dashboard shows how many goods requests are currently open, how many you've pledged to, and a "Recommended For You" section suggesting open requests in categories you've helped with before.

4.4 Messaging the home

Once the home accepts your pledge, a Messages panel appears on the request's page so you can coordinate directly — pickup times, access instructions, or anything else specific to that donation. You'll be notified whenever the home sends a message.

5. Delivery Volunteer Guide

A Delivery Volunteer works the same way as a Donor for the purposes of this platform: you browse and pledge to goods requests, with the understanding that your role is specifically to transport items rather than necessarily supply them yourself. You do not need a police clearance, and you never have direct, unsupervised contact with children through the platform.

Follow the same steps as the Donor Guide (Section 4) for browsing, pledging, and tracking a delivery. Your sidebar shows this list under "Deliveries" instead of "Donation Requests", but it is the same underlying list of goods requests.

6. Service Provider Guide

6.1 Completing your profile

Before you can offer services, you must register a Service Provider profile and be approved by an administrator.

1. From your Dashboard, click "Complete your Service Provider registration".
2. List your skills, any qualifications, and select every service category you can offer (Tuition, Counselling, Healthcare, Sports Coaching, Maintenance, Other).
3. Choose your Service Mode: "Onsite" if you will have direct, in-person contact with children, or "Online only" for remote services.
4. Submit. If you chose Onsite, you must also upload a Police Clearance Report — this is mandatory and cannot be waived. Online-only providers may skip this.
5. An administrator will review your profile and documents. You'll receive a notification (in-app and by email) once a decision is made.

Note: You cannot pledge to any service request until your profile is Approved, and — if your service is Onsite — until your police clearance is specifically verified, even after approval of the rest of your profile.

6.2 Offering a service

Once approved, browse Service Requests from your Dashboard or sidebar, filter by category and urgency, and pledge exactly as described for Donors in Section 4.2 — the same accept/in-progress/delivered/completed lifecycle applies, except there is no delivery method choice for services.

7. Children's Home Guide

7.1 Registering your home

1. From your Dashboard, click "Complete your Children's Home registration".
2. Enter your home's name, government registration number, contact details, and address.
3. Submit, then upload your documents on the profile page that appears — each required document type has its own upload button; uploading a new file for a type that already has one replaces it.
4. An administrator will review your submission. You cannot post requests until your home is Approved.

Note: If your registration is rejected, your profile page will show an "Edit & Resubmit" option — you can correct the issue and try again up to 3 times before needing to contact an administrator directly.

7.2 Posting a request

1. Once approved, click "Create a New Request" from your Dashboard or the "+ New Request" button on the Requests page.
2. Choose Goods or Service, then the specific category, a clear title, a description, quantity (for goods), and an urgency level.

3. Submit. Your request is now visible to Donors, Delivery Volunteers, or Service Providers depending on its type.
4. Optionally, open the request afterward and add photos — you can select several at once, and each is added rather than replacing the last.

7.3 Managing pledges

When someone pledges to your request, you'll be notified. Review their profile reputation (shown next to their name) before accepting. Once you accept a pledge, the fulfiller takes over marking progress; your job is to confirm completion once the goods or service actually arrive, and to leave a rating for the donor or provider.

7.4 When a volunteer pickup stalls

If a Donor chose "request a delivery volunteer" when pledging and there's been no progress for about a week, you'll receive a reminder notification. From the request's page, click "Arrange Alternative Delivery" to record your own arrangement — for example, a courier you've paid for — by describing it when prompted. The original Donor keeps credit for the pledge; they're simply notified that the delivery logistics changed.

7.5 Messaging

Once you've accepted a pledge, a Messages panel appears on the request's page — a simple, private conversation between you and whoever pledged, useful for coordinating pickup times, clarifying details, or working through a problem. Both of you receive a notification whenever the other sends a message.

7.6 Browsing Donors

Use "Browse Donors" in your sidebar to see a public reputation list of registered Donors — helpful context before accepting a pledge from someone you don't recognize.

8. Administrator Guide

8.1 Verifying Children's Homes and Service Providers

The Verification Queue (sidebar) lists every pending submission. Review the submitted details and uploaded documents (click "View documents" on each card), then Approve or Reject with a reason. For Service Providers who are Onsite, you must explicitly confirm you've checked their police clearance document before the system will allow an Approve decision to go through.

8.2 Managing users

User Management lets you search all accounts and Suspend or Reinstate any non-administrator account. A suspended user cannot log in — even an already-issued session is invalidated immediately. Always provide a reason when suspending; it is shown to the affected user and recorded in the Audit Log.

8.3 Moderating content

The Flagged Content page shows every request currently flagged as inappropriate, regardless of its lifecycle status. From a request's own detail page, you can flag or clear a flag, and remove an individual inappropriate image without cancelling the whole request.

8.4 Reports

The Reports page shows platform-wide statistics — request volumes, user counts, suspensions, and average reputation — with CSV and PDF export for offline reporting.

8.5 Audit Log

A read-only, chronological record of every significant action taken on the platform: verification decisions, suspensions, content moderation, and admin account creation. Nothing here can be edited or deleted.

8.6 Provisioning a new administrator

New administrator accounts are not created through the public registration form. This requires direct API access with a bootstrap secret known only to your technical administrator — ask them if you need a new admin account created.

9. Understanding Request Status

Every donation or service request moves through the same lifecycle:

Status	Meaning
Created	Posted by a Home, visible to Donors/Providers, no one has pledged yet
Pledged	Someone has offered to fulfil it; awaiting the Home's acceptance
Accepted	The Home has accepted the pledge; work can begin
In Progress	The fulfiller is actively working on or transporting the donation/service
Delivered	The fulfiller has marked it complete on their end; awaiting Home confirmation
Completed	The Home has confirmed receipt — the request is finished and can now be rated
Cancelled	Withdrawn by the Home, or by an administrator resolving a dispute

Note: A request can also be Flagged by an administrator at any point in this lifecycle. Flagging hides it from public browsing without changing its underlying status — it is a separate, independent moderation action.

10. Notifications

You'll receive both an in-app notification (bell icon, top right) and an email for these events: verification decisions, a pledge on your request, a pledge being accepted, delivery marked,

completion confirmed, a new rating received, your content being flagged, and account suspension or reinstatement.

Click the bell to see your recent notifications; click any notification to jump straight to the relevant page and mark it read. "Mark all read" clears your unread count in one click.

11. Frequently Asked Questions

Why can't I post a request yet as a Children's Home?

Your home must be Approved by an administrator first. Check your profile page for your current status and any rejection reason.

My Children's Home / Service Provider registration was rejected — can I try again?

Yes. Open your profile page, review the rejection reason, click "Edit & Resubmit", correct the issue, and submit again. You can resubmit up to 3 times. If you exhaust all 3 attempts, the page will direct you to contact an administrator directly, since the platform can no longer resolve it through self-service.

Why can't I pledge to a service request as a Service Provider?

Your profile must be Approved, and if you registered as Onsite, your police clearance must also be specifically verified — approval alone isn't enough for Onsite providers.

I didn't receive my verification or login code email — what do I do?

Check your spam folder first. Use the "Resend" option available on the relevant screen. If it still doesn't arrive after a few minutes, contact your platform administrator.

Can I edit a request after creating it?

Only while it is still in Created status (before anyone has pledged). Once pledged, its core details are locked to keep the fulfiller's commitment meaningful.

I uploaded the wrong document — can I fix it?

Yes. On your profile page, click "Replace" next to that document type and choose the correct file — it immediately replaces the old one. Request photos work differently: you can add as many as you like, and removing one (while the request is still open) doesn't affect the others.

Why can't I see the Messages panel on a request?

Messaging only opens once a pledge has been accepted, and only between the two people involved: the home and whoever pledged. It won't appear before a pledge exists, and no one outside that pair can see or join the conversation.

What happens if I get a low rating?

Ratings build your reputation score. If your average score falls below a threshold after several ratings, you may be temporarily restricted from pledging to new requests. This is a platform-wide trust and safety measure, not a permanent ban.

Who can see my contact details?

Your email and phone number are never shown in the Donor/Service Provider directory or on request listings. Only administrators reviewing your verification documents see full contact details.